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Mat Domber

Mat Domber is a jazz enthusiast and owner of Arbors Records. He and his wife Rachel have made an important contribution to the classic jazz scene by recording artists such as Dan Barrett, Ken Peplowski, Kenny Davern, and the Statesmen of Jazz.

Mat was interviewed in New York City on January 12, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Mat Domber with me today, founder of Arbors Records and longtime jazz fan.

MD: Absolutely. Jazz fan first of all. Businessman last of all.

MR: I think you'd have to be a true jazz fan to do what you do, right? A labor of love?

MD: Well it's a labor of love. It started really as a way of helping a musician friend of mine to be publicized and to get more work, get more gigs, by having his name associated with records which he had never done before. But over time it sort of grew like topsy. And we started, our first record came out in 1990 and to date we've put out probably close to 220 CDs which, for a Mom and Pop organization, is a lot of music.

MR: Yeah. You have a staff of what, three or four people?

MD: Well we have my wife Rachel who does our marketing and handles the books, we have Claudia, my executive assistant, who does everything, and her husband Dave who handles our shipping and stockroom and all of that. And that's Arbors Records.

MR: Well you certainly have come up with a good niche and I think established a great reputation. But I'm glad I got to hear you talk this morning because you said some, I think, significant things in that you don't necessarily care for labels in marketing jazz or in jazz in general?

MD: That's right. We don't. Because good music is good music. And if you label something as let's say Dixieland for example, people think of Shakey's Pizza Parlor and they think of sleeve garters and they think of striped shirts. And they forget the musical importance of that style of music and actually the difficulty of creating it. It's a kind of music that's so easy to play poorly and so difficult to play well.

MR: That's a great statement.

MD: But that's only one aspect of it. I mean jazz has become so broad that it's even very difficult to define. What is jazz today? I mean Kenny G, is he jazz? Is polytonal New Orleans music jazz? I mean and everything in between. Music is music.

MR: You said something this morning about a collection of sounds that is supposed to elicit some kind of emotional response.

MD: Right. And that I think is one of the important things about music, music in general, whether it's classical music, whether it's jazz. It's related to emotion. And one of the problems that I think has happened to the way in which even jazz has been moving is that it's lost its soul. It's lost that emotional impact. It's become a technical exercise. It's become something to display the virtuosity of the musician but it doesn't expose his heart and soul. And earlier jazz did just that. It didn't have quite the virtuosity but it had feeling, it had soul, it had something that you take away that's memorable. Something that's — even with the early musicians — as somebody commented, Wycliffe Gordon commented this morning — it has, you could recognize a musician by his tone, by his phrasing, as an individual. A lot of that is lost. More and more music is homogenized. And when you listen to it you can hardly tell who it is that's playing.

MR: It's a common observation I think, especially from people in my generation and older. But you know I went down last night to hear one of the groups for a while and that's the feeling I got. The only emotion I got was that guy playing the sax is having a great time playing as much as he can as fast as he can. And it was, from a technical standpoint, being a saxophone player especially, I said wow he can really play. But other than that —

MD: But what did he say?

MR: He wasn't telling any stories as they say.

MD: You see I come from the school of Flip Phillips, Coleman Hawkins, Lester Young, where the playing evoked an emotional response, whether it could be blues or whether it could be joy or whether it could be just the emotion of speed. Whatever it is, that's what they were trying to do. They were trying to convey something. Lester Young said when he played he heard the lyric in his mind. And he would be playing in a way to bring out what he thought was the message of the music. That's lost.

MR: Yeah. Was the music, this kind of music, prevalent in your house when you were growing up?

MD: Yeah. From the time I was maybe eight or nine years old my father bought a radio and in those days it had a victrola attachment to it, and in those days when they sold those things they also had records that went along with it. So one of the first things that we had in our house was the "Overture of William Tell" and Benny Goodman, some of the early Benny Goodman trios and quartets and some of the big band stuff. And I started to listen to that. Then I became an Eddie Condonite. And before I was old enough to be able to drink, my father, who liked to have his little Seagrams and Seven you know, and that sort of thing, we used to be down to Nick's and he didn't like the music particularly but he knew that I appreciated it and he used to stand there at the bar and I tried to emulate Pee Wee Russell

and Muggsy Spanier. I mean those were the people that I grew up with as a listener. And I was always a jazz fan. All my life I collected records and that sort of thing. And then I met up with a musician by the name of Rick Fay. Rick was playing in California and I used to go out to California on business and we got to be friends and we discovered that we had a lot of musical tastes in common. And then when they opened the — and he played at the Disney park in Anaheim — and then when they opened the park in Orlando they asked him to come over from California to lead one of the bands. And we'd moved down to Florida. I got involved in business in Florida and I came down and one day he called me and he said "hey you've got to come up here and hear this group that I've got, really a hot group." So I did, and that was Rick Fay's Hot Five that was playing at a little bar, the Cork Room in Orlando, Florida. And after the performance I said to Rick, "Gee this group really sounds good, I'd like to get some of your records." And Rick said, "I've never recorded." I said, "You've been in the business for 40 years and you've never recorded? Would you like to?" And that really, in 1989, was our first recording session. It came out in 1990. And that sort of changed me from just a fan to maybe a participant in the business of music. And then one thing led to another. I mean one musician introduced me to another, I broadened my listening interests from strictly Pee Wee Russell and Muggsy Spanier and Eddie Condon and Wild Bill Davison you know, and all of that stuff, and traveled around with Rick to various festivals where he started to perform. I got to know some musicians. We met Dan Barrett. Dan had played with Rick when he was about 16 years old in California. And one day Rick called me and said you know Dan had a very nice music career and was building a following at Concord but they were no longer interested. For some reason or other Carl Jefferson didn't like trombones I understand. But in any event they dropped Dan as one of their contract artists. So Rick said to me, "Gee it would be nice to do a record with Dan Barrett." Because I discovered that in order to get publicity, in order to get circulation for a record you couldn't just have one. No distributor wanted to handle your product if you had one CD. They want a continuing flow of business and a continuing flow of music. So I decided well I was very fortunate that we got a couple of reviews of Rick Fay's music in *Jazz Times* and other places, but there was no follow-up. So I said yeah, let's do the record with Dan Barrett. So we did and through Dan, Dan became our music director for a while, and through him I got to meet people like Howard Alden and Ken Peplowski and people that were part of his circle. And gradually things expanded. And everything happened by happenstance. I mean I never really set out to build —

MR: You never had a big business plan and here's how we're going to do this.

MD: No. Nothing like that. I never set out to build a jazz label or anything else, it just sort of happened. Then the other major thing that really happened to us was Rick was doing a

concert in St. Petersburg and for some reason or other the bass player who was supposed to be playing, this was about 1991 I would say, the bass player who was supposed to be playing with us couldn't show up. So we were nervous about a bass player and somebody said to Rick there's a guy by the name of Bob Haggart, who is a well known bass player, who lives in Venice, Florida. Why don't you give him a call and see if he'd be interested. I thought to myself I knew about the Bob Crosby Band, I knew about the World's Greatest Jazz Band and all of that. I said Bob Haggart? He wouldn't want to come up here to St. Petersburg to play with us. But I called him. And Bob said, "Great, I'd love it." Bob was the kind of guy, a fantastic musician of course. But also he was a man without really any ego in the sense that he just loved to play. He wouldn't care if he was playing with a good group at a local bar, he would love it. If he was playing at Carnegie Hall he would love it as long as the musical atmosphere was one that he enjoyed being with. So he came up, he didn't care about the money or anything else. And he played. And from that point on we became friends. And he was on a couple of records with us. And then one day we were doing a record, I'll never forget, in Orlando with Chuck Hedges, a wonderful clarinet player. Bob was playing bass. And we stayed together at a hotel for the record session. And this was like 1993. And we were having breakfast with Bob and his wife Wendy. And I happened to make a casual remark, you know, that it'd be lovely to put on a jazz party or a jazz festival because that's a good way to market the music and it's a good way to expose the music. And Wendy said, "Well you know next year in 1994 my husband's going to be 80 years old." And I said, "By God that's a wonderful way to present a jazz party in honor of Bob Haggart's 80th birthday." And that was our first March of Jazz. And that, you see, led me into a whole different range of music. It led me into the people who played with Bob and the people who Bob knew, because in order to put on the party I said Bob, "It's your birthday, you pick the musicians." So who did he pick? Flip Phillips, Bob Wilber, Kenny Davern, Ralph Sutton, the people who were meaningful. Bobby Rosengarden. I mean the people who were meaningful to him in his career, who were still alive. Yank Lawson, and were playing, and that got me started with a whole new group of people. So everything happened sort of by chance. It was never designed. At that party I was talking to Flip Phillips and his wife Miki said, "Well you know next year Flip is gong to be 80 years old." So that was our second March of Jazz party and then it just went on until 2004. We put on ten of them and then it was enough.

MR: Have you ever been to any of those jazz parties yourself?

MD: Sure.

MR: Okay. Because it was so odd. When we started doing these interviewing sessions I had not been aware of this jazz party phenomenon. And Milt Fillius hipped me to it, and he

said, "Here's a good way to get some of these interviews is you go and you be there for the three days. And I was amazed that such a thing existed. I sort of didn't know about it. But I also was amazed at how hip the audience was that came to these things. I just — you don't expect people to be so informed about the music.

MD: Well don't forget, don't forget, we were dealing with the jazz parties with a generation that grew up with the music. I mean these were people, for example, who used to see Ralph Sutton at Sunnie's Rendezvous in Aspen and who used to see these musicians play in the clubs in New York at the time, you know, the hotels. The hotels had swing music, had jazz music, there were clubs and these were people who grew up with the music just as the later generation grew up with the Beatles, these were people who grew up with Benny Goodman, grew up with Artie Shaw, grew up with Eddie Condon, etcetera, etcetera. If you remember, Eddie Condon was really one of the great publicists. His wife worked for a PR firm, an advertising firm, and he had *Life* magazine, he had tremendous — he had people like Steinbeck who came down and I mean it was the hip thing of that day. Now these were the people who came later on to the so-called jazz parties. Dick Gibson I think was the first one who really popularized that kind of thing. And unfortunately I never went to any of his parties so that when we started I just sort of had to be reinventing the wheel myself because I didn't really know how these other parties had functioned but I just decided, in my own mind, what I would like and what I would like to see or how I would like to present it, and sort of went on that way.

MR: As a producer of these things, did you ever have to deal with personality conflicts between the musicians?

MD: Sure.

MR: They are people too, right?

MD: Well when you're dealing with musicians you're dealing with artists. When you're dealing with artists there are always personality issues, there's always ego — this guy doesn't like the other guy, this guy had a gig but he never invited me to play with him so I don't want to play with him. You know you always have things of that kind that go on. Usually you can help smooth it over. Sometimes you just make sure that they stay separated.

MR: That's great. Do you consider yourself, in your — when you make a new CD — are you the producer in the sense that do you direct the music that's going to go on the —

MD: I'm not a musician. I don't know one chord from another if push came to shove. I decided that what I would do is leave the music to the musicians. So normally what I will do is choose somebody who I'd like to record or choose a group that I'd like to record. And I ask the leader to select the musicians that will help him to present his music the way he wants to present it, or her, we record women as well as men. And I leave the

choice of tunes to them, I leave the editing of the music to them, although occasionally I might have an opinion, but I don't think that I know as much about music as Ruby Braff did or know as much as Kenny Davern or any of these people, so why should I try to tell them? But the strange thing that started to happen with the recordings that we did, that they would ask me for my opinion. And I was always very flattered when Kenny Davern would say, "Well which take did you prefer?" And I'd think to myself my God, you're asking me? And sometimes I came up with an answer that he agreed with and sometimes I didn't.

MR: How much time in the studio do you usually feel you're able to afford for these musicians? Do you give them guidelines for that?

MD: No.

MR: Really?

MD: We generally book ten hours, two five hour sessions. And normally that's enough to produce one CD. If it runs over in time and if we have to work instead of until six o'clock at night and we have to go to eight or nine, that's fine. The music is the thing. I always figure to myself when you amortize the additional costs over the lifetime of the music it becomes inconsequential.

MR: Oh, that's a good way to look at it. It's also interesting that that's really how jazz records used to be made too. They would do one or two sessions and get your album made, rather than with pop records sometimes they take months and months.

MD: Well we don't record the way some pop albums are recorded where you have a guitar player in California and a singer in New York and a bass player in Texas you know. And they all lay down their tracks and then somehow they get all mixed together and put together. We don't do that. We like the synergy of having the musicians face to face playing together. We think that's important.

MR: Is there ever an issue about musicians who would like to include some of their original compositions? And when I think about what makes a person buy a CD it's got to be partly that they look at the songlist.

MD: True.

MR: I like the artist but I also like six of these nine songs.

MD: You'd be amazed at how many people turn over the CD and look at the songlist at the back and say oh yeah, "Sweet Sue" I have that, as if one version of "Sweet Sue" covers the entire gamut of what that song can convey and express and what an individual musician will do with it in playing. But it's amazing, yes, the songlist is important to some people. But to really answer your question, no I actually encourage musicians to do their original work because as I said I think the essence of music making is to give free

rein to the musician to present himself the way he would like to be presented. And if original music is part of that presentation, yeah, sure.

MR: Excellent. It helps to keep the music fresh, and as you said — we were talking about this morning — they were talking about the word "traditional" and that you don't really care for it because it means old fashioned.

MD: Well I think that's what it conveys. I think it conveys to people Shakey's Pizza Parlor. Again, with sleeve garters and striped shirts and funny hats and all of that stuff. And to a lot of the black musicians it conveys something of the kind of music that they don't want to be associated with anymore.

MR: I'm glad you brought that up because it seems that when you go to hear traditional jazz played, or ever classic jazz, you see very few black musicians playing it anymore.

MD: True. We have a group called the Statesmen of Jazz and it's a nonprofit 501C3 corporation. The purpose is to promote and preserve the heritage of jazz through performances by outstanding musicians. And we do clinics in the schools as well. We always try to have at least one black musician on stage with our musicians at the same time to convey a message that we think that jazz is neither black nor white, there are elements of black origin and black participation and elements of white musical participation that makes up the whole melange of music. And it's very difficult to find black musicians who know the tunes. That's the problem. They play very well but they're coming up through a different kind of orientation. They're coming up without really a knowledge of the tunes. They might know a fragment of melody but they don't know the tune, they don't know the chords, they don't know the chord changes. And that makes it difficult sometimes to find black musicians who, particularly younger ones, older ones we have quite a few who play. But mostly those were musicians who came up through the ranks of melody, of swing, of a time when there was a lot more integration between black and white musicians.

MR: More integration than there is now?

MD: I think so. But I'm looking at it from my own perspective. I really can't speak statistically or speak through the entire panorama of music. But all I can really say is that among the musicians that I have experience with it's hard to find a lot of black musicians who play the Great American Songbook, who play the kind of standards that our Statesmen kind of groups generally play.

MR: I know you want to move this.

TH: I want to move this because it's now hitting my microphone.

MD: Oh, I'm sorry.

TH: And while I'm here, I'll get you — let me fill you up. So don't' start talking about anything.

MD: I won't say a word. I don't say anything important anyway so what's the difference?

MR: So how was your flight up here?

MD: Well actually I came up Wednesday but I had to fly to Pittsburgh on business and I came back last night.

MR: Did you do other business? I mean obviously where did you make your living?

MD: I'm a lawyer by trade. And somehow I found my way into the development business and we built a string of senior citizen housing, Section 8 housing, in Pennsylvania and West Virginia and from that we got into the management business to manage those projects.

TH: When you finish this, you start with a question for me so that when we go back we go back we go back together. Thank you.

MD: And that's what keeps jazz alive in my mind. It's not a profitable operation, the way we do it anyway.

MR: Right okay.

MR: This morning you were saying that jazz is not a profitable operation in fact I think it's a bit of an oxymoron like the rich jazz musician.

MD: Yeah. That's right. How do you make a million dollars in the music business? You start with two.

MR: That's a good one. When you look at the festival here, the jazz convention—

MD: You mean the IAJE?

MR: The IAJE. You had this panel this morning about Trad Jazz is Alive and Well. Well first of all I wonder who came up with that title?

MD: I don't know. Probably somebody on their staff here that does the convention planning came up with it.

MR: Yeah. So and then they find some people who will talk about that. But there's not much traditional, I mean we don't want to label it but we still need to call it something. There's not much traditional jazz on the menu as far as the performing groups.

MD: Really there are none that are overtly labeled as traditional. There are some that play some swing and that sort of thing. But there's nothing being featured.

MR: And I wonder why that it is. It seems like everybody really wants to do what's happening now and be a part of what is going to happen I guess.

MD: I don't know, it's a very difficult question for me to answer because I'm not that attuned to the educators and the people who make up the core group of the IAJE. I mean after all it is jazz education, it is the people who have the music programs in the schools and the colleges etcetera. I'm not really that attuned to their thinking. But I think in part it's a desire to present what they consider to be the music of today and what they consider to be the kind of music that will make a musician employable. One of the things that I think, if you go to the clubs for example, Blue Note, the Evening Times and Birdland and clubs in

other parts of the country, there are very few outlets for so-called traditional jazz. Most of the jazz that you hear is bebop and post-bebop kind of music. And so I think the schools, whether consciously or subconsciously, are trying to prepare the musicians that they're teaching to exist in that environment. Because after all, music is a business.

MR: Yes. But I would vehemently disagree with that approach.

MD: Good. I'm glad. Go ahead.

MR: Well — you will turn the tables on me and start interviewing me — but as a working musician I can tell you when I go out to play a jazz gig, if people hire me to play a jazz gig, not necessarily in a club but at a party or something, I don't play John Coltrane tunes. I play the American Songbook. And that's what people want to hear.

MD: They don't come to the clubs to hear it, I'll tell you that.

MR: No they don't come to the clubs, but how much club work — there's more work playing private engagements or that kind of thing, at least where I live. I work all the time. And I don't play the kind of music that I hear here. Now I understand it's easier to teach that music I think, because they've come up with ways of codifying it. I think it's harder to teach traditional jazz and so they don't. I don't think they know how to teach that music.

MD: Well I think that's — I won't disagree with what you're saying — but I can only relate to my individual experience and what you're talking about is a style and a manner of music that was very, very common years ago. I don't know how common it is anymore, in reality. You know there were the weddings and the bar mitzvahs and the private parties and such, and a lot of the musicians that I knew and I grew up with, they made a nice living doing that as well as exposing their music in the clubs and places where people could hear them and want to hire them for private events. And that was a very important way also for young musicians to get started in the business because in order to sit in with them they had to learn the tunes, they had to know the proper chord changes, and this was their education. While obviously there is some of that that still goes on, it doesn't go on in quite the way it used to.

MR: Right. It's unfortunate because there's a lot, there's more also from learning about playing those kinds of gigs, you know how to program a set, how to be professional, how to be comfortable on the stage and talk to people, that whole thing about being a performer you don't learn in the classroom.

MD: I think that's very true. Of course it's always true in any kind of education. I mean take law school for example. Law school doesn't really prepare you to practice law as such. It doesn't prepare you for the practicalities of the practice of law. I mean it teaches you how to read a case, it teaches you perhaps how to reason, and it teaches you perhaps about certain substantive facts about different aspects of the law, but it doesn't really teach you how to practice law. I sort of get the feeling that musical education is somewhat the same

way. I mean it teaches you what the chords are, it teaches you how to play your instrument, it teaches you a little bit about harmony perhaps, teaches you other things that are related, but I don't really know how well it teaches you how to prepare yourself for the experience of earning money as a musician.

MR: Right. It seems like —you know, the good old days — I guess there used to be more opportunities to make a lousy living than there are now. Now there is fewer opportunities to make a lousy living.

MD: That's right. That's right. I mean even, you play here in the clubs, I mean the pay scale is equivalent to what it was forty years ago. It's very hard for musicians to make a decent living playing, particularly playing jazz. Well of course playing jazz, even in the heyday of swing music, jazz musicians never really made a living.

MR: Right.

MD: They always worked the thirty dollar gigs, or at that time the thirty-five dollar gigs in places, you know, in the smoky bars. But they had a certain joy of doing it. Kenny Davern used to tell me that he loved the smoke, he loved the atmosphere of the clubs and the bars, you know, thick with smoke and booze and all of that stuff. And that was where jazz was born and that was really the atmosphere in which jazz was created. We've lost a lot of that because you can't smoke anymore.

MR: Right, I know.

MD: Most of the people from those days are on AA or worse. It's different. Of course we also had — somebody should write a book someplace, sometime, about the influence of the mob on jazz. You know it was the mobsters who owned most of the clubs. It was the mobsters who, in Chicago and New York, who hired the jazz musicians who somehow or other liked jazz themselves and used it in the speakeasies and in the clubs etcetera, and that opened up a whole world. Maybe they still do but more respectably, I don't know.

MR: I know that we were all really shocked when Kenny died. He was a big part of your label for sure. Was there something in particular that you liked about his playing?

MD: Well yes, almost everything. Yeah Kenny's death came as a great shock. As a matter of fact we have a record that's going to be coming out very shortly, that we recorded a while ago in 2005 actually, of Kenny and Ken Peplowski. And just the day before he died he was talking with my assistant Claudia. Dan Morgenstern has written the album notes for the CD and he was just talking with her about some changes that he wanted or suggested in the notes. And no, there was no premonition that he had a heart problem or anything else. He just, at ten o'clock one night, the next night he complained of pains in his chest and within an hour he was dead. But my initial attraction with Kenny came from the fact that I knew that he was one of the legatees of Pee Wee Russell. And even before I got to know Kenny personally, Pee Wee Russell was one of my idols. When I was 13 years old

I studied the clarinet for one year and I used to sit on the edge of my bed in the room trying to emulate Pee Wee Russell's solos and the sounds and the croaking sounds that he made. And when I realized that I didn't have the talent to be able to do that I gave up the clarinet after one year. That was it. That was my whole musical education in one year. But I knew, for example, that Kenny Davern was a good friend and that Pee Wee in some ways was a mentor to him and that he inherited Pee Wee's clarinet and so there was, I felt, a certain initial bond that I had to Kenny before I even knew him or anything else. And of course I'd heard a lot of his records and such and knew about him. And when we had the chance to have him perform at our first March of Jazz party in 2004 that's where I really started to get to know him and Bob Wilber both. And we discovered — I discovered that he was a man who was not only a consummate musician but he was a very interesting person besides. He had a world of knowledge about a lot of subjects. He read extensively. He delved into classical music and into opera and he was a man of decided likes, dislikes and opinions.

MR: That's for sure.

MD: And we became very good friends. And I considered it a great pleasure and an honor to be able to record him.

MR: He had a certain legato tonguing style on his instrument I really, really like. And I just am always amazed at his inventiveness with creating melodies, which is what I like to hear in an improviser.

MD: Yeah, right, exactly, exactly. To him tone was extremely important. He always strove to get the best clarinet tone that he could. He didn't believe in a lot of notes, he believed in choosing the notes carefully that he wanted to play but to play them well and to play them in tune and with the proper sound. He liked rhythm.

MR: He loves guitars for sure.

MD: Well in this record that I mentioned, that will be coming out soon, which will be called "Dialogues" with Ken Peplowski, we have James Chirillo and Howard Alden, two guitars, no piano. Two guitars, bass and drums.

MR: Returning to your label for a second, the brochure says classic jazz lives on. Did you have a discussion about what exactly are we going to put there. I mean you did not put traditional jazz lives on, you didn't put just jazz lives on. Was that a sort of a big decision?

MD: Well I don't know if it was a big decision but it was a decision. I was trying in some way to identify what we were trying to do in a way that would be meaningful to the people who were interested in the kind of music that we were producing and that they would recognize what we were trying to do. But at the same time I didn't want it to be restricted. I felt, as I said a couple of times when we were talking here, that traditional jazz meant

Shakey's Pizza Parlor and Dixieland bands and everything else, and while we record some music in that style, that's not all that we do. And I was looking for a way to describe it. I don't know that classic is exactly right but it's as close and I could think of at the time to describe what we're doing.

MR: And it's not like you just have older musicians, I mean you've got some great young talent here.

MD: Well we recorded Aaron Weinstein when he was 19 years old. Bucky Pizzarelli brought him to us and said here's a guy that you should listen to and I'd like to do a record with him. And I said well, Bucky, if you'd like to do a record with him so would I. So we recorded Aaron and at that time he hadn't even started at Berklee. Now he's at Berklee in Boston. And he's a marvelous violinist and he not only is going to school but he's also developing quite a professional career for himself.

MR: You've seen the, sort of the technology-wise at least, that cassettes have now become way passe. Do you worry about what's going to happen next?

MD: Maybe I should but I don't. When we started, as I say, our first record came out in 1990, most of our audience were cassette oriented. They weren't interested in CDs at that time. But I felt, and we used to produce both cassette versions and a CD version of what we did. Eventually we dropped the cassettes and now we produce solely CDs and sort of musical taste — not taste but musical technology has broadened sufficiently so that virtually everybody has a CD player in their car or has a CD player at home or such. There's no problem about having audiences that are able to play the music as you produce it. I think that there is a lot of new technology that's out there, but a lot of people have been burned also because they invested in cassettes and then along came CDs and now you've got DVDs which have also got other kinds of formats that are competing with the DVDs and I don't think the people are buying that stuff. I mean maybe there are some technology-oriented people who always want to be on the cutting edge of the music, but people are a little wary. I mean they started with Beta and then along came VHS, and then along came DVD to supplant that, and you know, people get a little wary about investing too much in any one of these technologies, not knowing how the future will be. And quite frankly, I don't know that we're — when I say we I mean Arbors Records — is ready to move into a technological frontier at this time. We were at the time — at the time that we put out our first CDs that was an adventurous thing. Because there weren't that many CDs that were on the market and there weren't that many companies that were doing CDs. It was mostly cassettes and vinyl.

MR: And do most of your sales come through mail order?

MD: Well it's an interesting question. We do have Allegro Music in Portland, Oregon as our principal distributor in the U.S. and Canada, and we have distributors in various countries

overseas. But we don't really sell a lot of our product. Somehow or other our product is more influential than the sales volume that we have of a particular CD. We get a lot of radio play, we get a lot of good reviews in jazz publications. We do have a website so that we do get a lot of mail order business. And now what's starting to take hold is digital downloading. We have a lot of our catalogue on these digital downloading sites, you know ninety-nine cents a track, you know, that sort of thing.

MR: Okay well that was really my question regarding technology, that you are taking advantage of that.

MD: Yes. Well we're linked to it in the sense that we've only really started in the last year or so to take advantage of it. On our website we always had snippets of our records, you know 45 seconds of this or that, but we've never really gone into digital downloading and digital direct marketing. But we are going to be doing a lot more of that because I think that's the wave of the future.

MR: Does it seem to, have you been able to tell so far, if it's working as far as your getting compensation.

MD: Yeah.

MR: Okay, that's great.

MD: Yeah we have a company that handles that. We got it through our distributor, Allegro. They have a company that they're working with in turn.

[audio buzz]

MR: I don't know what that is.

TH: I don't know but they're driving me crazy. It could be two floors down in a wall.

MD: Anyway we have a company that we've been working with through our distributor, Allegro Music, and that's starting to become a fairly significant income stream for us. And it's something that I think is increasing. And one of the things that we want to try to do is to make that fact more available.

MR: We'll just call it sound effects.

MD: Right. But make it more available because the whole secret of web marketing is that people know you're there and people will come to look for you, and how — this is something I was talking with the product manager for jazz of Allegro is here at this convention and we were just talking about that, how to make our downloading more visible.

MR: Has he got a booth?

MD: No. They had one last year but they don't have one this year.

MR: So now you're doing also the jazz cruises?

MD: Well yes. We've done several with a company called Jazzdagen, which is interesting because Jazzdagen essentially has presented cruises, they put on maybe seven or eight or

481 even more a year, mostly with trad band groups. The principal, Alita Myers, her husband
482 is a wonderful clarinet player and he leads a group called High Sierra, which is a well
483 recognized trad band that plays these festivals and such. And the thought was that it
484 would be interesting to combine our kind of music, our all-star music, with her trad
485 music, to broaden the audience. I felt it would be nice because it would expose — that's
486 tough, it's tough to compete with somebody drilling in the streets — but it would help to
487 expose some of her audience to our kind of music and some of our people might enjoy
488 hearing that kind of music as well. So we've done one cruise a year we've done, but we
489 have another one that's going to be coming up December 1st leaving out of Miami going
490 through the Caribbean and we have people like Warren Vache and her husband's group,
491 and it should be interesting.
492 MR: Right. Again when I look at those lineups and even from the jazz parties that are still
493 around, I see a lack of black musicians most of the time, or too often the time. Does that
494 go back to what you were talking about before, they just don't seem to fit into that?
495 MD: We've always had black musicians or at least we've tried to have black musicians at our
496 parties. We, again, I felt that the music is color blind and gender blind. We have women
497 who we think are good performers who fit in. The whole issue is fitting in. I mean you
498 know, Milt Hinton was at our parties while he was alive of course, and came — we
499 honored him on his birthday as one of our — we had Benny Waters and we had Benny's,
500 I think he was 95 at the time, and we presented a tribute to Benny as part of our March of
501 Jazz. We've had Joe Wilder. But the problem has always been to find musicians that
502 would fit in, who would be able to play with the group as a whole, would know the tunes
503 and would be able to perform. And with our Statesmen of Jazz group we've been able to
504 reach out to more and more musicians. I mean we have people like Norman Simmons
505 who play regularly with us and we put Norman together with Warren Vache you know,
506 and they play together beautifully. Rufus Reid playing bass in our group, Bobby
507 Cranshaw playing bass, so that we try to do that. But it is a problem. And of course I have
508 to say that you know if you bring up the subject of race I mean that raises other issues.
509 There aren't too many black people who come to our parties as audience. I can't speak
510 for why but there are very, very, very few. And in terms of jazz producers, building a
511 bottom line, they're looking at inviting musicians who they think will have a following,
512 who they think will bring an audience to them, and that too is a factor in how many black
513 musicians they want to invite. Now on the other side of the coin you have the group that
514 puts on cruises where they have a lot of black musicians who are playing on the cruises,
515 with white musicians I mean, and they get a large black audience. But it's funny, when
516 you go on those cruises you see that most of the black audience will go to those
517 performances where the black musicians are playing, and not too many of them come in

to where the white musicians are playing, which is a shame because in the early days of music, the early days of jazz, although the country was segregated, the music wasn't. And very often in the recording studios you'd have white and black musicians who were recording together while they couldn't appear together on stage. And they jammed together and they learned from each other, and that was very, very interesting. Plus the fact that so many of the black musicians had teachers who were white. Buster Bailey, for example, went to the same music teacher that Benny Goodman did in Chicago.

MR: Oh, right.

MD: And I'm sure that there are many, many, many more examples that you could quote. So it's an unfortunate thing but I think that part of it too related to economics. I think that the black musicians, with justification, felt that they were, for a long, long time, excluded from the better paying jobs and the better hotel work, from the jobs that white bands were getting. And when the circle turned I think they felt that they wanted to do their thing and take advantage of their thing and why should they bring in other people to participate in what they felt was their chance to make a few bucks.

MR: Yeah. It's a really complicated issue for sure.

MD: Yes it is. And it's cultural as well as musical.

MR: I think, were you saying that — someone this morning was talking about — maybe it was Jim Cullum — that you can't really separate American culture when you study jazz history. It's all one and the same.

MD: I think I made that comment.

MR: I think you did.

MD: But others might have made the same thing. Yeah it's true, it's true. You can look at, I've always felt that our segregated society had a lot to do with the music with the evolution of the music during those times. I think also the rise of the black power movement after World War II had a lot to do with the direction that music took at that time. And in that sense the music was really related to the culture and the cultural phenomena that were taking place at the time.

MR: Well just to wrap up, do you get a lot of musicians sending you things? I want to be on your label, here's my CD.

MD: Yes. We do.

MR: It's so easy to make CDs now you know.

MD: Yes. We do get a lot of that and it helps me sometimes to know or at least recognize a name or recognize some music, but very, very, very seldom do we follow-up to record. I mean after all is said and done we're still a Mom and Pop operation. We turn out anywhere between 15 and 20 CDs a year, which is a lot for us. And we have artists that we regularly record and every once in a while we slip in a new one or somebody else that

has come to us and who makes a particular impression, usually somebody that another musician has recommended because I feel sometimes that if Bucky Pizzarelli says that this guy really is good and really has something important to produce or create I would listen much more than I would otherwise.

MR: Actually to the person himself, right?

MD: That's right. Absolutely. Because as I said, I'm not a musician. I approach music as a fan. And as a fan, you know, you have certain things that you like, certain things that you don't like. I can't really express it in musical terms but you express it more in feeling and emotional terms and so I don't know if a guy is playing the wrong chords, I don't really know if he's missed this or has missed that in his solo. I just listen to it and see what it sounds like to me.

MR: Right. But you know if they're not eliciting some emotional response, don't you?

MD: That's right. Because that's what I look for. That to me is an essential part of the music.

MR: Well I want to thank you for what you do because a record like Kenny Davern with Strings with arrangements by Bob Haggart and —

MD: That wasn't ours.

MR: Oh is that right?

MD: No that was Music Masters.

MR: Okay, but you know —

MD: But that was Kenny's favorite actually. Of all the records — he loved the quartet records that he did with us, you know, The Outpost and at Mill Hill Playhouse, and some of the other things that we did together, but I think his all-time favorite was really that record. And unfortunately Bob Haggart passed away before — he passed away very suddenly too and he was going to do some more arrangements with Kenny before he died.

MR: Well the things you do are really important documentations and I think these musicians are probably very happy you're around.

MD: I think that's true. I think that we've helped to expose a lot of musicians, to get people to hear their music and know about them, get them gigs, because they became better known, and that's all been to the good. That's one of our purposes. I mean I'm less interested, to be perfectly honest, I'm less interested in amassing great sales or doing hip hop or something like that, than I am in promoting the kind of music that I love.

MR: Well, well said. Thanks for your time today.

MD: Well thank you, Monk, it's really been a real pleasure to sit down here and chat with you.

MR: Good.